Order of Children

Children within a family group should be ordered chronologically, i.e. in order of birth, and not anti-chronologically, and the order of multiplets born on the same day should be preserved.

Although it would certainly make some sense to let applications put children in order, it is current practice to let the user decide the order of children. Users expect genealogy applications to respect the order they choose, and not change it on import on export.

Genealogy Application Best Practice

- encourage users to enter dates, including approximate dates
- Encourage users to put and keep children in order:
  - when you show children, show their birth (or baptism) dates
  - visually indicate problems with the order of children
  - alert users when they insert a child out of order
  - include a children-in-order check as a basic genealogy consistency check
- Preserve the order of children across GEDCOM import and export
- optionally: make ordering children easy with a reorder children function
- checking chronological order
  - *when checking*, treat dates consisting of just a year as January 1 of that year
  - *when checking*, treat dates consisting of just a year and a month as the first day of that month
  - for multiplets born on the same day, simply respect the order chosen by the user

References

- Marriage in GEDCOM
- Married, Divorce, Married Again
- Same-Sex Marriage in GEDCOM

INDIVIDUAL_RECORD:=

n <XREF:INDI> **INDI**	{1:1}	
+1 <<PERSONAL_NAME_STRUCTURE>>	{0:M}	p. 72
+1 SEX <SEX_VALUE>	{0:1}	p. 105
+1 <<INDIVIDUAL_EVENT_STRUCTURE>>	{0:M}	p. 69
+1 <<INDIVIDUAL_ATTRIBUTE_STRUCTURE>>	{0:M}	p. 68
+1 <<CHILD_TO_FAMILY_LINK>>	{0:M}	p. 67
+1 <<SPOUSE_TO_FAMILY_LINK>>	{0:M}	p. 75
+1 <<ASSOCIATION_STRUCTURE>>	{0:M}	p. 65
+1 REFN <USER_REFERENCE_NUMBER>	{0:M}	p. 107
+2 TYPE <USER_REFERENCE_TYPE>	{0:1}	p. 107
+1 RIN <AUTOMATED_RECORD_ID>	{0:1}	p. 78
+1 <<CHANGE_DATE>>	{0:1}	p. 66
+1 <<NOTE_STRUCTURE>>	{0:M}	p. 71
+1 <<SOURCE_CITATION>>	{0:M}	p. 73
+1 <<MULTIMEDIA_LINK>>	{0:M}	p. 71

The individual record is a compilation of facts, known or discovered, about an individual. Sometimes these facts are from different sources. This form allows documentation of the source where each of the facts were discovered.

The GEDCOM 5.5.5 INDI is significantly simpler than the GEDCOM 5.5.1 INDI record; All the GEDCOM 5.5.1 subrecords that were marked obsolete or deprecated in the *GEDCOM 5.5.1 Annotated Edition* have been removed.

The INDI.SEX record is optional. When absent, systems *must* assume the default <SEX_VALUE> of U.

The normal lineage links are shown through the use of pointers from the individual to a family group through either the FAMC tag or the FAMS tag. The FAMC tag provides a pointer to a family group record where this person is a child. The FAMS tag provides a pointer to a family group record where this person is a spouse or parent. The <<**CHILD_TO_FAMILY_LINK**>>, page 67 structure contains a FAMC pointer which is required to show any child to parent linkage for pedigree navigation. The <<CHILD_TO_FAMILY_LINK>> structure also indicates whether the pedigree link represents an official lineage (birth record), or an adoption lineage.

Linkage between a child and the family group they belonged to at the time of an event can also be shown by a FAMC pointer subordinate to the appropriate event. For example, a FAMC pointer subordinate to an adoption event indicates a relationship to a family group by adoption. Official parents can be shown by a FAMC pointer subordinate to the birth event (optional).

Other associations or relationships are represented by the <<**ASSOCIATION_STRUCTURE**>> (the ASSO record).

Order of Parents

The INDI record may contain more than one FAMC subrecord, with each INDI.FAMC record pointing to a family group the individual was part of at sometime. These should be listed chronologically; thus, the official parents should be listed first, and the current legal parents should be listed last.

References

Behold blog: Sex in GEDCOM

MULTIMEDIA_RECORD:=

n <XREF:OBJE> **OBJE**	{1:1}	
+1 **FILE** <MULTIMEDIA_FILE_REFERENCE>	{1:1}	p. 95
+2 **FORM** <MULTIMEDIA_FORMAT>	{1:1}	p. 95
+3 TYPE <SOURCE_MEDIA_TYPE>	{0:1}	p. 106
+2 TITL <DESCRIPTIVE_TITLE>	{0:1}	p. 89
+1 REFN <USER_REFERENCE_NUMBER>	{0:M}	p. 107
+2 TYPE <USER_REFERENCE_TYPE>	{0:1}	p. 107
+1 RIN <AUTOMATED_RECORD_ID>	{0:1}	p. 78
+1 <<NOTE_STRUCTURE>>	{0:M}	p. 71
+1 <<SOURCE_CITATION>>	{0:M}	p. 73
+1 <<CHANGE_DATE>>	{0:1}	p. 66

The GEDCOM 5.5.1 <<MULTIMEDIA_RECORD>> allowed a single OBJE record to link to multiple related files.
That GEDCOM 5.5.1 feature is not widely supported; many genealogy applications will read only the first OBJE.FILE, resulting in loss of data. It was deprecated in the GEDCOM 5.5.1 Annotated Edition.
GEDCOM 5.5.5 simplifies the multimedia support by no longer allowing multiple files per media record. There is one multimedia record per file, one file per multimedia record.

GEDCOM does not include any grouping or tagging mechanism for multimedia files.

GEDCOM does not define a standard for bundling multimedia files with a GEDCOM file.

NOTE_RECORD:=

n <XREF:NOTE> **NOTE** <USER_TEXT>	{1:1}	p. 108
+1 REFN <USER_REFERENCE_NUMBER>	{0:M}	p. 107
+2 TYPE <USER_REFERENCE_TYPE>	{0:1}	p. 107
+1 RIN <AUTOMATED_RECORD_ID>	{0:1}	p. 78
+1 <<SOURCE_CITATION>>	{0:M}	p. 73
+1 <<CHANGE_DATE>>	{0:1}	p. 66

REPOSITORY_RECORD:=

n <XREF:REPO> **REPO**	{1:1}	
+1 **NAME** <NAME_OF_REPOSITORY>	{1:1}	p. 96
+1 <<ADDRESS_STRUCTURE>>	{0:1}	p. 64
+1 <<NOTE_STRUCTURE>>	{0:M}	p. 71
+1 REFN <USER_REFERENCE_NUMBER>	{0:M}	p. 107
+2 TYPE <USER_REFERENCE_TYPE>	{0:1}	p. 107
+1 RIN <AUTOMATED_RECORD_ID>	{0:1}	p. 78
+1 <<CHANGE_DATE>>	{0:1}	p. 66

SOURCE_RECORD:=

n <XREF:SOUR> **SOUR**	{1:1}	
+1 DATA	{0:1}	
+2 EVEN <EVENTS_RECORDED>	{0:M}	p. 92
+3 DATE <DATE_PERIOD>	{0:1}	p. 85
+3 PLAC <SOURCE_JURISDICTION_PLACE>	{0:1}	p. 106
+2 AGNC <RESPONSIBLE_AGENCY>	{0:1}	p. 104
+2 <<NOTE_STRUCTURE>>	{0:M}	p. 71
+1 AUTH <SOURCE_ORIGINATOR>	{0:1}	p. 106
+1 TITL <SOURCE_DESCRIPTIVE_TITLE>	{0:1}	p. 105
+1 ABBR <SOURCE_FILED_BY_ENTRY>	{0:1}	p. 106
+1 PUBL <SOURCE_PUBLICATION_FACTS>	{0:1}	p. 106
+1 TEXT <TEXT_FROM_SOURCE>	{0:1}	p. 106
+1 <<SOURCE_REPOSITORY_CITATION>>	{0:M}	p. 74
+1 REFN <USER_REFERENCE_NUMBER>	{0:M}	p. 107
+2 TYPE <USER_REFERENCE_TYPE>	{0:1}	p. 107
+1 RIN <AUTOMATED_RECORD_ID>	{0:1}	p. 78
+1 <<CHANGE_DATE>>	{0:1}	p. 66
+1 <<NOTE_STRUCTURE>>	{0:M}	p. 71
+1 <<MULTIMEDIA_LINK>>	{0:M}	p. 71

Source records are used to provide a bibliographic description of the source cited. (See the <<SOURCE_CITATION>> structure, page 73, which contains the pointer to this source record.)

SUBMITTER_RECORD:=

n <XREF:SUBM> **SUBM**	{1:1}	
+1 NAME <SUBMITTER_NAME>	{1:1}	p. 106
+1 <<ADDRESS_STRUCTURE>>	{0:1}	p. 64
+1 <<MULTIMEDIA_LINK>>	{0:M}	p. 71
+1 RIN <AUTOMATED_RECORD_ID>	{0:1}	
+1 <<NOTE_STRUCTURE>>	{0:M}	p. 71
+1 <<CHANGE_DATE>>	{0:1}	p. 66

The submitter record identifies an individual or organisation that created the GEDCOM file. All records in the GEDCOM file are understood to be submitted by the same individual or organisation.

A GEDCOM 5.5.5 file contains exactly one <<SUBMITTER_RECORD>>, directly after the <<HEADER>>. There is no need for the HEAD.SUBM pointer anymore, so it optional now.

Subrecords of the Lineage-Linked Form

ADDRESS_STRUCTURE:=

n **ADDR**	{1:1}	
+1 ADR1 <ADDRESS_LINE1>	{0:1}	p. 75
+1 ADR2 <ADDRESS_LINE2>	{0:1}	p. 75
+1 ADR3 <ADDRESS_LINE3>	{0:1}	p. 75
+1 CITY <ADDRESS_CITY>	{0:1}	p. 75
+1 STAE <ADDRESS_STATE>	{0:1}	p. 76
+1 POST <ADDRESS_POSTAL_CODE>	{0:1}	p. 76
+1 CTRY <ADDRESS_COUNTRY>	{0:1}	p. 75
n PHON <PHONE_NUMBER>	{0:3}	p. 99
n EMAIL <ADDRESS_EMAIL>	{0:3}	p. 75
n FAX <ADDRESS_FAX>	{0:3}	p. 75
n WWW <ADDRESS_WEB_PAGE>	{0:3}	p. 76

History

The GEDCOM 5.5.1 specification supports both new style structured addresses (subrecords for separate address parts) and old style unstructured addresses (a single line value with line breaks). Structured addresses were introduced in GEDCOM 5.4 (1995), although the ADR3 tag was only added in GEDCOM 5.5.1 (1999).
The new style structured addresses were introduced to replace the old style unstructured addresses. GEDCOM 5.5 (1996) understandably continued to allow the use of old style unstructured addresses for backward compatibility with applications that did not support GEDCOM 5.5 yet. GEDCOM 5.5.1 (1999) continued to allow the old style unstructured addresses. The GEDCOM 5.5.1 Annotated Edition (2018) explicitly deprecated the old style, unstructured addresses. GEDCOM 5.5.5 supports structured addresses exclusively. The ADDR line must not have a line value.

Structure

Notice that the <<ADDRESS_STRUCTURE>> isn't a single GEDCOM record, but one mandatory record and a few optional records.
The <<ADDRESS_STRUCTURE>> always includes the ADDR record, while the PHON, EMAIL, FAX and WWW records are optional.
Note that these optional records may only appear in combination with the mandatory ADDR record; on this point, GEDCOM 5.5.5 agrees with GEDCOM 5.5.1, not GEDCOM 5.5.

PHONE, EMAIL, FAX & WWW

The PHON, EMAIL, FAX, and WWW records are *not* subrecords of the ADDR record, nor does the GEDCOM specification define another record that all these records are a subrecord of. The PHON, EMAIL, FAX, and WWW records simply appear at the same level as the ADDR record.

Although the order of different records at the same level should not matter, it is strongly suggested that GEDCOM writers always put the mandatory ADDR record first, and any optional PHON, EMAIL, FAX and WWW records directly after that.

Home, Work and Mobile

The <<ADDRESS_STRUCTURE>> allows up to three PHON records, EMAIL, FAX & WWW records. This allows inclusion of say a home, work and mobile phone number, but GEDCOM does not provide a mechanism for indicating which phone number is which.

PAF Addresses use URL instead of WWW

FamilySearch PAF uses GEDCOM 5.5.1, but PAF addresses do not use the WWW tag specified here, they use the illegal tag URL instead. That is an error in PAF, and FamilySearch should have fixed PAF. Instead, FamilySearch “fixed” the GEDCOM specification: in GEDCOM 5.6, the tag has changed from WWW to URL.

Best Practices

GEDCOM Writer Best Practice

- Write the mandatory ADR record before any of the optional records
- Write any optional records directly after the mandatory ADR record

GEDCOM 5.5.1 Writer Best Practice

- Use structured addresses exclusively

GEDCOM 5.5.1 Reader Best Practice

- Accept URL as a synonym for WWW
- Do issue an non-fatal error stating that the URL tag is illegal

GEDCOM 5.5.5 Reader Best Practice

- Do not accept any nonsense

References

- GEDCOM ADDR

ASSOCIATION_STRUCTURE:=

n **ASSO** <XREF:INDI>	{1:1}	p. 108
+1 **RELA** <RELATION_IS_DESCRIPTOR>	{1:1}	p. 0
+1 <<SOURCE_CITATION>>	{0:M}	p. 73
+1 <<NOTE_STRUCTURE>>	{0:M}	p. 71

The association pointer only associates INDI (individual) records to INDI (individual) records.

The ASSO record may only be used for relationships that aren't otherwise supported by the Lineage-linked Form. Parent-child relationship must be recorded using the INDI.FAMC and the FAM.CHIL records.

The person's relation or association is the person being pointed to. The association or relationship is stated by the value on the subordinate RELA line. For example:

0 @I1@ INDI
1 NAME Fred /Jones/
1 ASSO @I2@
2 RELA Godfather

This GEDCOM fragment states that `@I2@` is Fred's godfather.

The <RELATION_IS_DESCRIPTOR> does not provide a list of standard values. The ASSO.RELA line value is free-form text that has meaning to the user, not the application.

GEDCOM-L ASSO.RELA

The ASSO.RELA value should be assumed to be nothing but user-provided text, but it is worth noting that German developers working together through the GEDCOM-L mailing list have agreed to use the following values where appropriate:

- `Godparent`
- `Witness_of_Birth`
- `Witness_of_Death`

GEDCOM-L _ASSO.RELA

They also use a GEDCOM extension, the _ASSO record, for relationship from an individual to a couple, with the following agreed-upon _ASSO.RELA values:

- `Witness_of_Marriage`
- `Witness_of_Civil_Marriage`
- `Witness_of_Religious_Marriage`

Discommended

Earlier versions of GEDCOM featured support for witnesses through the WITN record. FamilySearch GEDCOM 5.4 eliminated the WITN record. Various genealogy software developers solve that limitation through GEDCOM extensions, most commonly through a _WITN record.
This ASSO and _ASSO records approach is strongly discommended.

Witnesses should not be associated with a couple. Witnesses must be associated with the event they witnessed. This _ASSO record approach fails to associate witnesses with an event and because of that, cannot even tell you which marriage someone witnessed.
It is better to use some product-specific _WITN record on the event itself.

References

GenWiki: GEDCOM/ASSO-Tag

Best Practice

- Applications should not assume any particular ASSO.RELA value has any particular meaning.
- Applications should issue a strong warning when an ASSO.RELA value seems to duplicate a familial relationship (e.g. grandfather)

CHANGE_DATE:=

n **CHAN**	{1:1}	
+1 **DATE** <DATE_EXACT>	{1:1}	p. 83
+2 TIME <TIME_VALUE>	{0:1}	p. 107
+1 <<NOTE_STRUCTURE>>	{0:M}	p. 71

The change date is intended to only record the last change to a record. Some systems may want to manage the change process with more detail, but it is sufficient for GEDCOM purposes to indicate the last time that a record was modified.

CHILD_TO_FAMILY_LINK:=

n **FAMC** <XREF:FAM>	{1:1}	p. 108
+1 PEDI <PEDIGREE_LINKAGE_TYPE>	{0:1}	p. 99
+1 <<NOTE_STRUCTURE>>	{0:M}	p. 71

EVENT_DETAIL:=

n TYPE <EVENT_OR_FACT_CLASSIFICATION>	{0:1}	p. 91
n DATE <DATE_VALUE>	{0:1}	p. 87
n <<PLACE_STRUCTURE>>	{0:1}	p. 72
n <<ADDRESS_STRUCTURE>>	{0:1}	p. 64
n AGNC <RESPONSIBLE_AGENCY>	{0:1}	p. 104
n RELI <RELIGIOUS_AFFILIATION>	{0:1}	p. 104
n CAUS <CAUSE_OF_EVENT>	{0:1}	p. 78
n <<NOTE_STRUCTURE>>	{0:M}	p. 71
n <<SOURCE_CITATION>>	{0:M}	p. 73
n <<MULTIMEDIA_LINK>>	{0:M}	p. 71

FAMILY_EVENT_DETAIL:=

n HUSB	{0:1}	
+1 AGE <AGE_AT_EVENT>	{1:1}	p. 0
n WIFE	{0:1}	
+1 AGE <AGE_AT_EVENT>	{1:1}	p. 0
n <<EVENT_DETAIL>>	{0:1}	p. 67

FAMILY_EVENT_STRUCTURE:=

[		
n [**ANUL** | **CENS** | **DIV** | **DIVF**]	{1:1}	
+1 <<FAMILY_EVENT_DETAIL>>	{0:1}	p. 67
|		
n [**ENGA** | **MARB** | **MARC**]	{1:1}	
+1 <<FAMILY_EVENT_DETAIL>>	{0:1}	p. 67
|		
n **MARR** [Y|<NULL>]	{1:1}	
+1 <<FAMILY_EVENT_DETAIL>>	{0:1}	p. 67
|		
n [**MARL** | **MARS**]	{1:1}	
+1 <<FAMILY_EVENT_DETAIL>>	{0:1}	p. 67
|		
n **RESI**	{1:1}	
+1 <<FAMILY_EVENT_DETAIL>>	{0:1}	p. 67
|		
n **EVEN** [<EVENT_DESCRIPTOR> | <NULL>]	{1:1}	p. 91
+1 <<FAMILY_EVENT_DETAIL>>	{0:1}	p. 67
]		

Residence isn't an Event but an Attribute

This <FAMILY_EVENT_STRUCTURE> definition includes RESI (residence) as a possible event. However, the residences of a family aren't events, they are attributes. A building has an age, but a residence has a period. Moving in and moving out are events, typically happening on a single day, while having residence is an attribute,

typical valid for a period of many years.

The miscategorisation of RESI as an event is a hold-over from earlier GEDCOM version. The FACT record was only introduced in GEDCOM 5.5.1. Prior to GEDCOM 5.5.1, FamilySearch did not really distinguish between events and attributes.

INDIVIDUAL_ATTRIBUTE_STRUCTURE:=

```
[
n CAST <CASTE_NAME>                                          {1:1}   p. 78
   +1 <<INDIVIDUAL_EVENT_DETAIL>>                            {0:1}   p. 69
   +1 TYPE <USER_REFERENCE_TYPE>                             {0:1}   p. 107
|
n DSCR <PHYSICAL_DESCRIPTION>                                {1:1}   p. 100
   +1 <<INDIVIDUAL_EVENT_DETAIL>>                            {0:1}   p. 69
   +1 TYPE <USER_REFERENCE_TYPE>                             {0:1}   p. 107
|
n EDUC <SCHOLASTIC_ACHIEVEMENT>                              {1:1}   p. 105
   +1 <<INDIVIDUAL_EVENT_DETAIL>>                            {0:1}   p. 69
   +1 TYPE <USER_REFERENCE_TYPE>                             {0:1}   p. 107
|
n IDNO <ID_NUMBER>                                           {1:1}   p. 93
   +1 <<INDIVIDUAL_EVENT_DETAIL>>                            {0:1}   p. 69
   +1 TYPE <USER_REFERENCE_TYPE>                             {1:1}   p. 107
|
n NATI <NATIONAL_OR_TRIBAL_ORIGIN>                           {1:1}   p. 99
   +1 <<INDIVIDUAL_EVENT_DETAIL>>                            {0:1}   p. 69
   +1 TYPE <USER_REFERENCE_TYPE>                             {0:1}   p. 107
|
n NCHI <COUNT_OF_CHILDREN>                                   {1:1}   p. 79
   +1 <<INDIVIDUAL_EVENT_DETAIL>>                            {0:1}   p. 69
   +1 TYPE <USER_REFERENCE_TYPE>                             {0:1}   p. 107
|
n NMR <NUMBER_OF_RELATONSHIPS>                               {1:1}   p. 99
   +1 <<INDIVIDUAL_EVENT_DETAIL>>                            {0:1}   p. 69
   +1 TYPE <USER_REFERENCE_TYPE>                             {0:1}   p. 107
|
n OCCU <OCCUPATION>                                          {1:1}   p. 99
   +1 <<INDIVIDUAL_EVENT_DETAIL>>                            {0:1}   p. 69
   +1 TYPE <USER_REFERENCE_TYPE>                             {0:1}   p. 107
|
n PROP <POSSESSIONS>                                         {1:1}   p. 102
   +1 <<INDIVIDUAL_EVENT_DETAIL>>                            {0:1}   p. 69
   +1 TYPE <USER_REFERENCE_TYPE>                             {0:1}   p. 107
|
n RELI <RELIGIOUS_AFFILIATION>                               {1:1}   p. 104
   +1 <<INDIVIDUAL_EVENT_DETAIL>>                            {0:1}   p. 69
   +1 TYPE <USER_REFERENCE_TYPE>                             {0:1}   p. 107
|
n RESI                                                       {1:1}
   +1 <<INDIVIDUAL_EVENT_DETAIL>>                            {0:1}   p. 69
   +1 TYPE <USER_REFERENCE_TYPE>                             {0:1}   p. 107
|
n TITL <NOBILITY_TYPE_TITLE>                                 {1:1}   p. 99
   +1 <<INDIVIDUAL_EVENT_DETAIL>>                            {0:1}   p. 69
   +1 TYPE <USER_REFERENCE_TYPE>                             {0:1}   p. 107
|
n FACT <ATTRIBUTE_DESCRIPTOR>                                {1:1}   p. 77
   +1 <<INDIVIDUAL_EVENT_DETAIL>>                            {0:1}   p. 69
```

```
    +1 TYPE <USER_REFERENCE_TYPE>                                  {1:1}    p. 107
]
```

The IDNO and FACT record both *require* a subordinate TYPE record to identify what kind of number or fact is being recorded.
The TYPE record *may* be used with each of the above tags used in this structure.

INDIVIDUAL_EVENT_DETAIL:=

```
n <<EVENT_DETAIL>>                                                 {1:1}    p. 67
n AGE <AGE_AT_EVENT>                                               {0:1}    p. 77
```

Attributes do not have Age

This FamilySearch GEDCOM 5.5.1 specification uses <INDIVIDUAL_EVENT_DETAIL> for both attributes and events. The inclusion of the AGE_AT_EVENT subrecord makes sense for events, but not for attributes.
Some attributes (for example residence and occupation) have *periods* associated with them.
The use of <INDIVIDUAL_EVENT_DETAIL> for attributes is a specification error, attributes should use a separate <INDIVIDUAL_ATTRIBUTE_DETAIL>.

INDIVIDUAL_EVENT_STRUCTURE:=

```
[
n BIRT                                                             {1:1}
    +1 <<INDIVIDUAL_EVENT_DETAIL>>                                 {0:1}    p. 69
    +1 FAMC <XREF:FAM>                                             {0:1}
|
n CHR [ Y | <NULL> ]                                               {1:1}
    +1 <<INDIVIDUAL_EVENT_DETAIL>>                                 {0:1}    p. 69
    +1 FAMC <XREF:FAM>                                             {0:1}
|
n DEAT [ Y | <NULL> ]                                              {1:1}
    +1 <<INDIVIDUAL_EVENT_DETAIL>>                                 {0:1}    p. 69
|
n [ BURI | CREM ]                                                  {1:1}
    +1 <<INDIVIDUAL_EVENT_DETAIL>>                                 {0:1}    p. 69
|
n ADOP                                                             {1:1}
    +1 <<INDIVIDUAL_EVENT_DETAIL>>                                 {0:1}    p. 69
    +1 FAMC <XREF:FAM>                                             {0:1}    p. 108
      +2 ADOP <ADOPTED_BY_WHICH_PARENT>                            {0:1}    p. 76
|
n [ BAPM | BARM | BASM ]                                           {1:1}
    +1 <<INDIVIDUAL_EVENT_DETAIL>>                                 {0:1}    p. 69
|
n [ CHRA | CONF | FCOM ]                                           {1:1}
    +1 <<INDIVIDUAL_EVENT_DETAIL>>                                 {0:1}    p. 69
|
n [ NATU | EMIG | IMMI ]                                           {1:1}
    +1 <<INDIVIDUAL_EVENT_DETAIL>>                                 {0:1}    p. 69
|
n [ CENS | PROB | WILL ]                                           {1:1}
    +1 <<INDIVIDUAL_EVENT_DETAIL>>                                 {0:1}    p. 69
|
n [ GRAD | RETI ]                                                  {1:1}
    +1 <<INDIVIDUAL_EVENT_DETAIL>>                                 {0:1}    p. 69
|
```

n **EVEN** [<EVENT_DESCRIPTOR> | <NULL>] {1:1} p. 91
+1 <<INDIVIDUAL_EVENT_DETAIL>> {0:1} p. 69
]

The GEDCOM 5.5.5 specification no longer allows the informationless GEDCOM record `1 BIRT Y`. The above definition includes the <EVENT_DESCRIPTOR> that was missing GEDCOM 5.5.1.

As a general rule, events are things that happen on a specific date. Use the date form 'BET date AND date ' to indicate that an event took place sometime between two dates. Resist the temptation to use a 'FROM date TO date ' form in an event structure. If the subject of your recording occurred over a period of time, then it is probably not an event, but rather an attribute or fact.

The EVEN tag in this structure is for recording general events that are not shown in the above <<INDIVIDUAL_EVENT_STRUCTURE>>. The event indicated by this general EVEN tag is defined by the value of the subordinate TYPE tag. For example, a person that signed a lease for land dated October 2, 1837 and a lease for equipment dated November 4, 1837 would be written in GEDCOM as:

1 EVEN
2 TYPE Land Lease
2 DATE 2 OCT 1837
1 EVEN
2 TYPE Equipment Lease
2 DATE 4 NOV 1837

The TYPE tag can be optionally used to modify the basic understanding of its superior event or attribute. For example:

1 GRAD
2 TYPE College

The occurrence of an event is asserted by the presence of either a DATE tag and value or a PLAC (place) tag and value in the event structure. When neither the date value nor the place value are known then a `Y` (yes) value on the parent event tag line is required to assert that the event happened. For example each of the following GEDCOM structures assert that a death happened:

1 DEAT Y
1 DEAT
2 DATE 2 OCT 1937
1 DEAT
2 PLAC Cove, Cache, Utah, United States of America

This convention asserts that the event happened.
It is not proper GEDCOM form to use a `N` (no) value with an event tag to record that it did not happen.

CHR Y, DEAT Y

The BIRT (birth), CHR (christening), and DEAT (death) dates may be unknown. The line value of these records may be empty (indicated by `<NULL>` in the definition), but, as stated in chapter 1, records must have value; the line value of most records may only be empty if it has subrecords. If there are no subrecords, the line value `Y` must be used.

The line `1 BIRT Y` means *born*; it provides no information whatsoever. The *GEDCOM 5.5.1 Annotated Edition* deprecated it. GEDCOM 5.5.5 makes it illegal.

The line `1 CHR Y` means *christened* (but do not know where or when), and the line `1 DEAT Y` means *died* (but do not know where or when).

MULTIMEDIA_LINK:=

n **OBJE** <XREF:OBJE>	{1:1}	p. 108

A <<MULTIMEDIA_LINK>> is a link to a <<MULTIMEDIA_RECORD>> (which is a link to a multimedia file).
There should be one multi-media record per file. There may be multiple multi-media links to a multi-media record.

The GEDCOM 5.5.1 specification demands support for the GEDCOM 5.5 <<MULTIMEDIA_LINK>>, because FamilySearch's own Personal Ancestral File (PAF) uses GEDCOM 5.5.1 yet uses the GEDCOM 5.5 <<MULTIMEDIA_LINK>>. That is a GEDCOM 5.5.1 specific issue. PAF does not create GEDCOM 5.5.5 files.
GEDCOM 5.5.5 does not tolerate the use of records defined in another GEDCOM version.

NOTE_STRUCTURE:=

[		
n **NOTE** <XREF:NOTE>	{1:1}	p. 108
|		
n **NOTE** <USER_TEXT>	{1:1}	p. 107
]		

A NOTE line value will frequently be too long to fit on a single GEDCOM line, thus necessitating the use of CONC and CONT records.
GEDCOM writers and readers must follow the rules in the *CONC & CONT* section. The essence is that a GEDCOM reader must accept all GEDCOM lines as-is, *must not* strip leading or trailing white space. That simple rule prevent the loss of white space between words.

PERSONAL_NAME_PIECES:=

n NPFX <NAME_PIECE_PREFIX>	{0:1}	p. 97
n GIVN <NAME_PIECE_GIVEN>	{0:1}	p. 97
n NICK <NAME_PIECE_NICKNAME>	{0:1}	p. 97
n SPFX <NAME_PIECE_SURNAME_PREFIX	{0:1}	p. 98
n SURN <NAME_PIECE_SURNAME>	{0:1}	p. 98
n NSFX <NAME_PIECE_SUFFIX>	{0:1}	p. 98
n <<NOTE_STRUCTURE>>	{0:M}	p. 71
n <<SOURCE_CITATION>>	{0:M}	p. 73

Rufnamen

It is odd that the GEDCOM specification does not support call names. Many Americans have German ancestors and in Germany, people do not just have call names, their rufnamen (call names) are *official*, recorded in official documents. German genealogy software uses the _RUFNAME record to record these call names.

References

- GenWiki: GEDCOM/NAME-Tag

PERSONAL_NAME_STRUCTURE:=

n **NAME** <NAME_PERSONAL>	{1:1}	p. 96
+1 TYPE <NAME_TYPE>	{0:1}	p. 98
+1 <<PERSONAL_NAME_PIECES>>	{0:1}	p. 71
+1 FONE <NAME_PHONETIC>	{0:M}	p. 97
+2 TYPE <PHONETISATION_METHOD>	{1:1}	p. 100
+2 <<PERSONAL_NAME_PIECES>>	{0:1}	p. 71
+1 ROMN <NAME_ROMANISED>	{0:M}	p. 98
+2 TYPE <ROMANISATION_METHOD>	{1:1}	p. 105
+2 <<PERSONAL_NAME_PIECES>>	{1:1}	p. 71

The name value is formed in the manner the name is normally spoken, with the given name and family name (surname) separated by slashes (/). (See <NAME_PERSONAL>, page 96 for examples.) Based on the dynamic nature or unknown compositions of naming conventions, it is difficult to provide more detailed name piece structure to handle every case.

The NPFX, GIVN, NICK, SPFX, SURN, and NSFX tags are not optional.
Usage of the GEDCOM records for name parts is mandatory (for every name part that has a value).

Systems that still do not produce these name part records on export cannot use GEDCOM 5.5.5, but must stick to using GEDCOM 5.5.1 or earlier. A GEDCOM 5.5.5 reader expects these name parts, and uses these to correctly split names into their parts.

A GEDCOM 5.5.5 reader *must* split a name as specified by the GEDCOM file, *must not* split a name any other way. A GEDCOM 5.5.5 reader must check that each <<PERSONAL_NAME_PIECES>> (the NAME record and all its subrecords) is self-consistent, and must report a fatal error and abort import when it is not.

A <NAME_TYPE> is used to specify the particular variation that this name is. For example; if the name type is subordinate to <NAME_PERSONAL>, page 96 it could indicate that this name is a name taken at immigration or that it could be an 'also known as' name (see NAME_TYPE, page 98.)

PLACE_STRUCTURE:=

n **PLAC** <PLACE_NAME>	{1:1}	p. 100
+1 FONE <PLACE_PHONETIC>	{0:M}	p. 101
+2 TYPE <PHONETISATION_METHOD>	{1:1}	p. 100
+1 ROMN <PLACE_ROMANISED>	{0:M}	p. 0
+2 TYPE <ROMANISATION_METHOD>	{1:1}	p. 105
+1 MAP	{0:1}	
+2 LATI <PLACE_LATITUDE>	{1:1}	p. 100
+2 LONG <PLACE_LONGITUDE>	{1:1}	p. 100
+1 <<NOTE_STRUCTURE>>	{0:M}	p. 71

Place Record Design Error

The FamilySearch GEDCOM 5.5.1 specification added the place coordinates, the LATI and LONG records, as subrecords of the PLAC record. That sounds reasonable and logical, there is no better place (pun intended) to put these. However, the PLAC record is itself a subrecord, and a typical GEDCOM file contains the same place names over and over again.

The GEDCOM 5.5.1 design seems to expect that GEDCOM writers, when place coordinates are known, include those coordinates with each occurrence of each place name, thus bloating GEDCOM files even more than frequently repeated place names

already do.
Worse than that, GEDCOM readers that come across the same place name more than once, may come across conflicting coordinates, and cannot resolve that by keeping all the different ones; this PLAC record allows just one set of coordinates.

Top-Level Place Record

Genealogy applications developers have long desired the introduction of a top-level place record, and the introduction of place coordinates in GEDCOM 5.5.1 made a top-level place record a practical necessity, yet it was still not included.

Top-Level _PLAC Record

Several developers have addressed this design error by introducing a top-level _PLAC record, and do not record place coordinates within PLAC records, but only within _PLAC records.
Different genealogy software developers use different top-level _PLAC records, but still match PLAC record with those _PLAC records the same way: a PLAC and _PLAC record match each other if they contain exactly the same place name string.

Top-Level _LOC Record

Several German software developers created a collective set of extensions called GEDCOM EL (Extended Locations). The GEDCOM EL extension were originally created for GEDCOM 5.5, but are also used with GEDCOM 5.5.1.
GEDCOM EL uses a top-level _LOC record.

References

- Gaenovium Presentations: Louis Kessler: Reading Wrong GEDCOM Right
- Behold blog 2011 Dec 24: The Place Record in GEDCOM
- Detecting GEDCOM EL
- GenWiki: GEDCOM 5.5EL

SOURCE_CITATION:=

n **SOUR** <XREF:SOUR>	{1:1}	p. 108
+1 PAGE <WHERE_WITHIN_SOURCE>	{0:1}	p. 107
+1 EVEN <EVENT_TYPE_CITED_FROM>	{0:1}	p. 92
+2 ROLE <ROLE_IN_EVENT>	{0:1}	p. 104
+1 DATA	{0:1}	
+2 DATE <ENTRY_RECORDING_DATE>	{0:1}	p. 91
+2 TEXT <TEXT_FROM_SOURCE>	{0:M}	p. 106
+1 <<MULTIMEDIA_LINK>>	{0:M}	p. 71
+1 <<NOTE_STRUCTURE>>	{0:M}	p. 71
+1 QUAY <CERTAINTY_ASSESSMENT>	{0:1}	p. 78

The data provided in the <<SOURCE_CITATION>> structure is source-related information specific to the data being cited. (See *Sample Lineage-Linked GEDCOM File*, page 110 for an example.)

The information intended to be placed in the citation structure includes:

- **!** The pointer to the <<SOURCE_RECORD>>, which contains a more general description of the source used for the fact being cited.
- **!** Information, such as a page number, to help the user find the cited data within the referenced source. This is stored in the ".SOUR.PAGE" record.
- **!** Actual text from the source that was used in making assertions, for example a date

phrase as actually recorded in the source, or significant notes written by the recorder, or an applicable sentence from a letter. This is stored in the ".SOUR.DATA.TEXT" record.

! Data that allows an assessment of the relative value of one source over another for making the recorded assertions (primary or secondary source, etc.). Data needed for this assessment is data that would help determine how much time from the date of the asserted fact and when the source was actually recorded, what type of event was cited, and what type of role did this person have in the cited source. {0:1} p. 106

- Date when the entry was recorded in source document is stored in the ".SOUR.DATA.DATE" record.
- The type of event that initiated the recording is stored in the ".SOUR.EVEN" record. The value used is the event code taken from the table of choices shown in the <EVENT_TYPE_CITED_FROM> primitive on page 49.
- The role of this person in the event is stored in the ".SOUR.EVEN.ROLE" record.

GEDCOM 5.4 (1995) introduced source citations using a reference to a (top-level) <<SOURCE_RECORD>> (SOUR record) and made it the preferred source citation format, to reduce redundancy. GEDCOM 5.5 and 5.5.1. continued to allow old format source citations that do not use SOUR record for backward compatibility with old systems, but clearly stated that the new format is preferred.
GEDCOM 5.5.5 no longer supports the old format, which has been deprecated since 1995. In GEDCOM 5.5.5, each source citation *must* reference a (top-level) SOUR record. Existing applications that still support the unstructured SOURCE_CITATION format should actively encourage users to upgrade all such citations (or at least the ones that cannot be mapped automatically), so that the user can take advantage of its GEDCOM 5.5.5 support.

SOURCE_REPOSITORY_CITATION:=

n **REPO** <XREF:REPO> {1:1} p. 108
+1 CALN <SOURCE_CALL_NUMBER> {0:1} p. 105
+2 MEDI <SOURCE_MEDIA_TYPE>

The <<SOURCE_REPOSITORY_CITATION>> is an optional subrecord of the <<SOURCE_RECORD>>.
Applications should encourage users to always reference a repository for consulted sources, but it isn't necessary to identify a particular repository for a widely available published work.

The <<SOURCE_REPOSITORY_CITATION>> is used for both formal and informal repositories. An example of an informal repository is an uncle who possesses an old bible that contains genealogical notes; you would enter his name and address as the repository. For formal repositories, such as a library, the call number of the particular source may be recorded.

The GEDCOM 5.5.5 <<SOURCE_REPOSITORY_CITATION>> definition is simpler than the GEDCOM 5.5.1 definition, because GEDCOM 5.5.5 demands that all systems support the <<REPOSITORY_RECORD>> record.

FamilySearch deprecated the NOTE-only <<SOURCE_REPOSITORY_CITATION>> format 25 years ago (see <<SOURCE_CITATION>> annotation about new structured format replacing the old unstructured format).
Existing systems that still support the NOTE-only format must encourage users to change such NOTE into a REPO records, so that the user can take advantage of its GEDCOM 5.5.5 support.

This structure is used within a source record to point to a name and address record of the holder of the source document. Formal and informal repository names and addresses are stored in the <<REPOSITORY_RECORD>>. Informal repositories include owner's of an unpublished work or of a rare published source, or a keeper of personal collections. An example would be the owner of a family bible containing unpublished family genealogical entries. More formal repositories, such as the Family History Library, should show a call number of the source at that repository. The call number of that source should be recorded using a subordinate CALN tag. Systems which do not use repository name and address record, should describe where the information cited is stored in the <<NOTE_STRUCTURE>> of the REPO (repository) source citation structure.

REPO.CALN.MEDI

There is a puzzling mistake that has, for the sake of full backward compatibility with (the not deprecated part of) the GEDCOM 5.5.1 structure, not been corrected in GEDCOM 5.5.5; the <<SOURCE_REPOSITORY_CITATION>> definition allows the CALN subrecord to have MEDI subrecord to specify a <<SOURCE_MEDIA_TYPE>>. That doesn't make sense.
The media type is a property of the source (<<SOURCE_RECORD>>), not of the repository, and certainly not of the call number.
Consider REPO.CALN.MEDI strongly deprecated.

SPOUSE_TO_FAMILY_LINK:=

n **FAMS** <XREF:FAM>	{1:1}	p. 108
+1 <<NOTE_STRUCTURE>>	{0:M}	p. 71

Primitive Elements of the Lineage-Linked Form

The field {Size=} specifications show the minimum and maximum field length. The field lengths are specified independent of other GEDCOM elements, such as level numbers and tags. GEDCOM lines are limited to 255 code units, but the GEDCOM grammar's CONC (concatenation) and CONT (continuation) records allow splitting a field over multiple lines.

ADDRESS_CITY:= **{Size=1:60}**

The name of the city used in the address. Isolated for sorting or indexing.

ADDRESS_COUNTRY:= **{Size=1:60}**

The name of the country that pertains to the associated address. Isolated by some systems for sorting or indexing. Used in most cases to facilitate automatic sorting of mail.

ADDRESS_EMAIL:= **{Size=5:120}**

An electronic address that can be used for contact such as an email address.

Email addresses contain a single at sign (@), but GEDCOM lines must not contain a single at sign.
In the GEDCOM grammar, a single at sign indicates the starts or end of an escape sequence.
The GEDCOM grammar states that a single at sign must be encoded as a double at sign.

- A GEDCOM writer must export the single at sign as two consecutive at signs.
- A GEDCOM reader must import that double at sign as a single at sign.

ADDRESS_FAX:= **{Size=5:60}**

A FAX telephone number appropriate for sending data facsimiles.

ADDRESS_LINE1:= **{Size=1:60}**

The first line of the address used for indexing.

ADDRESS_LINE2:= **{Size=1:60}**

The second line of the address used for indexing.

ADDRESS_LINE3:= **{Size=1:60}**

The third line of the address used for indexing.

ADDRESS_POSTAL_CODE:= **{Size=1:10}**

The ZIP or postal code used by the various localities in handling of mail. Isolated for sorting or indexing.

ADDRESS_STATE:= **{Size=1:60}**

The name of the province, state or similar country subdivision used in the address. Isolated for sorting or indexing.

ADDRESS_WEB_PAGE:= **{Size=4:2047}**

The world wide web page address.

Minimum and Maximum URL Length

Minimum URL Length

The actual minimum URL length is two letters: just a top-level domain. The only known example is the now retired URL shortener `to`, which consist of nothing but the country code for Tonga. The practical minimum for a field like this four letters, a one-letter second level domain on a two-letter top-level domain, for example `t.co`, twitter's URL shortener.

Maximum URL Length

There is no official maximum URL length, but there are practical limitations. RFC7230 recommends that length of at least 8000 bytes should be supported by all servers and clients, but practical limits are lower. Firefox support longer ULS, but will not display more than the first 65.536 code units of URL in the address bar. A default Apache server configuration has a 8192-byte limit on individuals fields of a request. The maximum length for an URL in a sitemap protocol is 2048 code units. Internet Explorer has a maximum URL length of 2083 code units, and that value is provided in `WinINET.h` as `INTERNET_MAX_URL_LENGTH`, but the address bar has a limit of 2047 code units.

The real-world answer is that very long URLs are a mistake, but it is not up to the GEDCOM specification to unduly limit the length of URLs. That is why the max length has been set to 2047 code units.

References

- Quora: What's the real minimum URL length?
- IEInternals: URL Length Limits
- stack overflow: What is the maximum length of a URL in different browsers?

ADOPTED_BY_WHICH_PARENT:= **{Size=4:4}**

[HUSB | WIFE | BOTH]
A code which shows which parent in the associated family group record adopted this person.

where:

HUSB = The HUSB in the associated FAM record adopted this person.
WIFE = The WIFE in the associated FAM record adopted this person.
BOTH = Both HUSB and WIFE adopted this person.

The names of the FAM.HUSB and FAM.WIFE subrecords are historical. These subrecords identify individuals, they do *not* indicate particular roles within the family group.

AGE_AT_EVENT:= {Size=2:13}

[NULL
| < + space
| > + space]
]
[YYY + y + space + MM + m + space + DDD + d
| YYY + y
| MM + m
| DDD + d
| YYY + y + space + MM + m
| YYY+ y + space + DDD + d
| MM + m + space + DDD + d
| CHILD
| INFANT
| STILLBORN
]

where:

>	= greater than indicated age
<	= less than indicated age
y	= a label indicating years
m	= a label indicating months
d	= a label indicating days
YYY	= number of full years, at most three digits
MM	= number of months, at most 11, at most two digits
DDD	= number of days, at most 365, at most three digits
CHILD	= age < 8 years
INFANT	= age < 1 year
STILLBORN	= died just prior, at, or near birth, 0 years
space	= U+0020, the Space character

Notice that, in the above syntax, the uppercase letters represents a number, while the lowercase letters are to be included literally, as part of the line value.

A number that indicates the age in years, months, and days that the principal was at the time of the associated event. Any labels must come after their corresponding number, for example; 4y 8m 10d.

The line value should be normalised; it should for example not specify `2y 13m`, but `3y 1m` instead. Number of days is allowed to be 365 because of leap years.

The YYY, MM and DDD values must not be zero; if a value equals zero, that part is left off. The values may not contain leading zeroes either.

The values CHILD, INFANT, STILLBORN have been deprecated because they break the mold, are technically superflous, and not likely to be understood as precise as they are defined here. They continue to be allowed for compatability with GEDCOM 5.5.1 only.

A notable shortcoming of the AGE_AT_EVENT syntax it that it does not support hours or minutes. Recording that a child died minutes or hours after birth is not supported.

ATTRIBUTE_DESCRIPTOR:= {Size=1:90}

Text describing a particular characteristic or attribute assigned to an individual. This attribute value is assigned to the FACT record. The classification of this specific attribute or fact is specified by the value of the subordinate TYPE record selected from the <EVENT_DETAIL> structure. For example if you were classifying the skills a person had obtained;

1 FACT Woodworking
2 TYPE Skills

ATTRIBUTE_TYPE:= **{Size=4:4}**

[CAST | EDUC | NATI | OCCU | PROP | RELI | RESI | TITL | FACT]
An attribute which may have caused name, addresses, phone numbers, family listings to be recorded. Its application is in helping to classify sources used for information.

AUTOMATED_RECORD_ID:= **{Size=1:12}**

A unique record identification number assigned to the record by the source system. This number is intended to serve as a more sure means of identification of a record for reconciling differences in data between two interfacing systems.

BEFORE_COMMON_ERA:= **{Size=2:4}**

[BCE | BC | B.C.]

<BEFORE_COMMON_ERA> allows three different values, all meaning the same thing. A GEDCOM 5.5.5 reader must support all three.
While enumerated values are case-insensitive, it is recommended that GEDCOM writers always use all-uppercase for those values, as that is what human readers examining GEDCOM files expect.

GEDCOM 5.5.1 specifies the use of `B.C.` (two full stops), but FamilySearch's own Personal Ancestral File (PAF) uses `BC` (just two letters) instead, and so do other applications. Therefore, the *GEDCOM 5.5.1 Annotated Edition* recommends that GEDCOM readers accept both values, *and* `BCE` as well.

A GEDCOM 5.5.5 reader cannot simply continue that GEDCOM 5.5.1 best practice, as a GEDCOM 5.5.5 reader *must not* accept invalid values. To continue to allow acceptance of both `B.C.` and `BC`, both are defined as legal. Both are deprecated as well, in favour of the religiously neutral `BCE` favoured by science and academia. A future GEDCOM version will use `BCE` exclusively.

Developers that aim for maximum compatibility of GEDCOM 5.5.1 and 5.5.5 files should use `B.C.` in their GEDCOM 5.5.5 files for now, *and* make sure their GEDCOM 5.5.1 reader accepts `BCE`.

CASTE_NAME:= **{Size=1:90}**

A name assigned to a particular group that this person was associated with, such as a particular racial group, religious group, or a group with an inherited status.

CAUSE_OF_EVENT:= **{Size=1:90}**

Used in special cases to record the reasons which precipitated an event. Normally this will be used subordinate to a death event to show cause of death, such as might be listed on a death certificate.

CERTAINTY_ASSESSMENT:= **{Size=1:1}**

[0 | 1 | 2 | 3]
The QUAY tag's value conveys the submitter's quantitative evaluation of the credibility of a piece of information, based upon its supporting evidence. Some systems use this feature to rank multiple conflicting opinions for display of most likely information first. It is not intended to eliminate the receiver's need to evaluate the evidence for themselves.

0 = Unreliable evidence or estimated data
1 = Questionable reliability of evidence (interviews, census, oral genealogies, or potential for bias for example, an autobiography)
2 = Secondary evidence, data officially recorded sometime after event
3 = Direct and primary evidence used, or by dominance of the evidence

CERTAINTY_ASSESSMENT

This simple four-value certainty assessment is arguably too simple and too subjective for serious use. It is not used much.
Several modern genealogy applications use a multi-value quality assessment, which is recorded as a GEDCOM extension.

COPYRIGHT_GEDCOM_FILE:= {Size=1:248}

A copyright statement needed to protect the copyrights of the submitter of this GEDCOM file.

The copyright-ability of GEDCOM files is a tricky topic. A typical GEDCOM is a selection taken from a compilation of facts, interpretations, and notes, complete with mistakes. Fact aren't copyrightable, but compilations and original notes are, and your interpretations and mistakes are your own. Then again, a small selection does not necessarily enjoy the same copyright protection as the entire work. You need a lawyer if you really care about this topic.

COPYRIGHT_SOURCE_DATA:= {Size=1:248}

A copyright statement required by the owner of data from which this information was downloaded.
This value occurs in the GEDCOM header; usage of CONC or CONT records is not allowed.

Actual examples are hard to come by, as the HEAD.COPR is rarely used. This is a GEDCOM header produced by Ancestral File 4.19:

```
0 HEAD
1 SOUR ANSTFILE
2 VERS 4.19
2 NAME Ancestral File (R)
2 CORP The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints

...
2 DATA Ancestral File
3 DATE 5 January 1998
3 COPR Copyright (c) 1987, June 1998
1 DEST PAF
1 DATE 6 FEB 2010
2 TIME 17:02:05
1 FILE GEDCOM4.ged
1 GEDC
2 VERS 5.5
2 FORM LINEAGE-LINKED
1 CHAR ANSEL
...
```

This example is part of an actual GEDCOM file created in 1998 which uses an old-style unstructured address, which were already deprecated but still legal in GEDCOM 5.5. To avoid giving a bad example, the old style address has been replaced with continuation dots.

COUNT_OF_CHILDREN:= {Size=1:3}

The known number of children of this individual from all relationships or, if subordinate to a family group record, the reported number of children known to belong to this family group (couple), regardless of whether the associated children are represented in the corresponding structure. This is not necessarily equal to the number of children referenced in the family group record.

DATE:= **{Size=4:35}**

[
<DATE_CALENDAR>
|
<DATE_CALENDAR_ESCAPE> + space + <DATE_CALENDAR>
]

where:

space = U+0020, the space character

Date Calendar Escape Sequence

It is odd that FamilySearch's lineage-linked form uses a GEDCOM escape sequence to specify the calendar. The calendar could easily be expressed with say a DATE.TYPE record.
In fact, the GEDCOM 5.6 draft (2000 CE) gets rid of the escape sequence by doing just that; it introduces the optional DATE.CLNDR record.

Changes

FamilySearch kept changing its mind about the calendar escape sequence. FamilySearch GEDCOM 4.0 introduced the calendar escape sequences, and GEDCOM 5.0 still featured them. FamilySearch GEDCOM 5.3 features the calendar escape sequences, but GEDCOM 5.4 does not, and states that “The Lineage-Linked GEDCOM Form is restricted to Gregorian calendar forms.”. FamilySearch GEDCOM 5.5 and 5.5.1 feature the calendar escape sequences, and GEDCOM 5.6 replaces it with a subrecord.

DATE_APPROXIMATED:= **{Size=8:39}**

[
ABT + space + <DATE> |
CAL + space + <DATE> |
EST + space + <DATE>
]

where:

ABT = About, meaning the date is not exact.
CAL = Calculated mathematically, for example, from an event date and age.
EST = Estimated based on an algorithm using some other event date.
space = U+0020, the Space character

About Abt

The FamilySearch GEDCOM specification provides three different date modifiers for approximated dates, with three slightly different definitions. The implied demand to use different date modifiers for slightly different situations is not placed on genealogy software, but on users. In practice, users almost always use `ABT`. Few users even know that usage of `CAL` or `EST` is possible.